

MEETING DATE: May 19, 2021 7:00 PM

Via Zoom

RE: Committee of the Whole Meeting

Budget Hearing Five

- Discussion of the development of the operating budget and budgetary priorities of the Medford Public Schools for Fiscal Year 2022 (July 1, 2021 - June 30, 2022) as it pertains specifically to Central Office of the Medford Public Schools including a variety of departments under the auspices of the Office of the Superintendent and the Office of Finance and Operations.
- Summary of the MPS budget presentations made throughout the course of all five Committee of the Whole budget meetings on May 3rd, May 6th, May 13th, May 18th, and May 19th.

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Breanna Lungo-Koehn: all present.

Dr. Edouard-Vincent: Tonight's meeting will address the budgetary concerns of the Central Office. Thank you to Mr. Murphy and to Michelle Kingdon for their hard work during this budget planning process.

Dave Murphy: Tonight is dealing with the Central Office. Showing Presentation. There will be an update on the budget at the next SC meeting on May 24. Feedback will be included in the final presentation on June 1. My hope is that the SC members and community members will see the transparency we have employed and the rationality behind the organization of these priorities.

What are the targets of the interventions we can offer to mitigate the academic/social emotional disruptions our students have experienced during the pandemic. Looking to make investments so that students' academic experiences are not defined by the pandemic. How can we use the funding from the state and local levels to help students.

Budget between 3.4 - 5.8 million dollars:

Funding from federal government and city and state governments still not clear

Fixed costs: due to contractual obligations that predate the development of the budget. We have

upwards of nine collective bargaining units that are soon expiring. Need to keep that in mind when building the budget.

ESSER budget over next several years: 2.3 and 5.3 m.

Hoping future data will point to increasingly efficient usage of the ESSER funding in the next couple of years. ESSER funding are one time funds - avoid creating structural deficits while meeting the current needs of students.

Building and Grounds: Most B&G costs are capital expenditures. Some costs get built into operating budgets. One time expenses are most often capital expenditures. Try to address the most urgent priorities and needs using the funding that is available.

John McLaughlin , Director of Buildings and Grounds: needs list and project we are working on

- Transformers/Amp breakers
- Security system enhancements: this year started using new scanners
- Parking lot striping project
- Pool infrastructure projects
- CTHS boiler project
- HVAC enhancement projects at outer schools - AC costs: contractor needs
- Restroom rehabilitation project at MHS: Need to issue RFPs for this project.
- MHS main entrance rehabilitation project.
- Truck and plowing equipment to more efficiently clear snow and open subsequent to winter storms
- Renovation of Caron Theater
- HVAC enhancement projects at MHS

Next Building and Grounds Subcommittee meeting on May 26th.

Dave Murphy: New cost due to the HVAC improvements: cost of replacement filters.

Central Admin. (\$75K) And Office of Finance and Operations Budget (\$110K)
Supt. Office: \$75 K: Professional Development

Dr. Edouard-Vincent: Value of quality professional development: shifts in the areas of social emotional learning: one area is how the district will deal with suspension. In addition to that, we

are continuing pursuit understanding and PD of implicit bias. Also going to offer PD on best practices with educator evaluation system. When we are addressing implicit bias, we also are working on anti-racism, cultural proficiency and anti-hate. Also looking at Disability awareness and impact of bias in the disability community.

Peter Cushing: Implicit bias using the train the trainer model which will allow us to deploy it across the year to meet needs.

Finance and Operations Office: \$110K

Repurposing of Before After School Programming Director as Director of Family Engagement with oversight of Parent Information Center, Before/After School, and as principal transportation liaison.

Diane Caldwell has been working as the lead manager of the Parent Information Center. Without Diane Caldwell providing assistance, it would have been a more difficult year. We have known that this was not a permanent solution. Operating within our budgetary parameters, Ms. Fiddler-Carey's willingness to take on additional responsibilities is an opportunity. This fits together as a full administrative portfolio. Family Engagement: PIC/BS-AS/Transportation. Require different degrees of detail at different times of the year. Fits together nicely as a 12 month position.

Grant Coordinator position: new position but not a real budgetary impact. Person has been working as an executive assistant in the past but has been executing grant oversight for some time. We don't have a grant writer role but looking to free capacity to give administrators ability to pursue grants with assistance of the coordinator.

The management solution has worked all year to create a report on the budgetary development process. Andy Paquette will continue to work on this.

FY22 Transportation Costs

Eastern Bus (just finished year one of 3 year contract) will increase by \$51K

MBTA Bus Passes: \$350,000 (all students)

MBTA Bus Passes for Econ. Disadvantaged students: \$150K

Additional one yellow bus for high school students up to \$75K

Additional two yellow buses for high school students will cost between \$75 and \$150K

It is not clear that there is a demand for this increase in bus service. MBTA bus passes provide more access to jobs and other experiences for students. Looking at all the options. Common thread: determination of extended school day using ESSER funds in school year 2021-2022.

Questions:

Paulette Van der Kloot: Buses: interesting options with quite big differences in pricing. Are you making a recommendation to us?

Dave Murphy: First determination if the committee is comfortable with the one mile radius for all grades with the exception of Kindergarten. There is potential in current contract that we will get an extra school bus. First is SC comfortable with the one mile radius? Next step look at the data for which high school students need bus service and what the route could be. MBTA buses are a better investment if we tie opportunities to their procurement.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Let's go back to the mile radius: I don't recall a vote on that.

Dave Murphy: When the reopening plan was presented, the radius were included in that. Ridership was so diminished this year.

Paulette Van der Kloot: In Medford there has been a history of kids getting bus service because of the busyness of the roads they live on.

Dave Murphy: Yes you are right. Safety is the other consideration. We are working with the Medford Police on determining those situations.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Any move to take away will cause an uproar. At the high end it is \$350k which is a large number.

Dave Murphy: This data is in response to inquiries from the committee.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I appreciate my colleagues raising this issue - clearly we will have more conversations on this.

Paul Ruseau: I am wondering where transportation for sports and band fits in?

Dave Murphy: It lives in the Fine Arts and sports budgets so they will be restored to FY2020 numbers to insure we have transportation to all events.

Paul Ruseau: We were more generous with sports transportation but the band had to sell stuff to get transportation. We need a breakdown on extra curricular spending per student. I really want to know that we are not prioritizing sports kids vs. band kids. Just using those examples - there are probably others. I would like to know that it is back to fair. This is the fourth budget where I have asked for this breakdown. Includes the stipends in the teachers' contracts. Is it actually fair?

David Murphy: I am happy to dig into that deeper to see if there are gaps. They are equally important programs for students.

Paul Ruseau: This is the fourth year of students trying to get menstrual products. There are CCSR projects making sure students have access to these products. I will not vote for any bathroom project without free access to menstrual projects.

Dr. Edouard-Vincent: when you make these statements, people will think we don't provide

them. We have an entire medical suite providing these products. They don't always get used appropriately. I want people to know they are available in the medical suite. That is why they were removed in the past. Available in all the nursing offices.

Paul Ruseau: I would just suggest that we get a map of the high school and consider how far a student can be from the medical suite.

Kathy Kreatz: The presentations were excellent and we will discuss the B/G items in next week's meeting. I pulled up the bulletin on transportation 2021 - "MPS will not transport students within two miles of where they attend." I don't recall having a meeting about this.

David Murphy: I say this with a disclaimer that this was before I was here; as it was explained to me, when the committee was presented with the 2.0 mile radius, it was for the secondary grades. There was a one mile radius at the elementary school that was not enforced. Kids in Kindergarten and on IEPs are not included in this conversation. This is what we go into planning with the vendor using. If we do, we could use the 18th bus of the fleet for the high school.

Peter Cushing: Safe routes to school has been a great project to decrease fossil fuel use and to look at other ways of providing safe opportunities for kids to get to school. These things played into the consideration last year when making the decisions last year. The principals met with families to map out routes to school. Opportunities to shift mindsets coming out of the pandemic.

Kathy Kreatz: Ms. Patterson was aware that with the MBTA, the days doesn't operate the high school routes the few days before Labor Day. Kids were late for school. In preparation for the upcoming school year, if there can be a school bus to pick up the students along the popular routes, that might be helpful. It is an ongoing issue each year.

Dave Murphy: I was unaware of this.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: It is a past practice in Medford and Eastern Bus is aware of it and they have shuffled their buses to get through the first three days. We will definitely continue that practice.

Dave Murphy: We will also push on the issue is what the capacity is on these buses? If there is a cost effective way of providing this to the high school, we will consider it.

Jenny Graham: I appreciate the attention to professional development. As long as there is a sustainability plan for the train the trainer model. I would like to make a motion that the transportation plan includes a clause that there will be no costs to students for transportation in the 2021/2022 school year and that we will get a plan by August 2021. Kids say that the MBTA bus makes them late. I would like us to revisit transportation and for all of you to work with eastern bus and MPD to determine the path forward,

I recall the nonenforcement of the radius at the elementary school. With kindergarteners having the ability to get on a bus where other kids can't makes it difficult to enforce

Melanie McLaughlin : Second the motion

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: What will they need to put in the budget if they don't give a plan by August 1.

David Murphy: There are different ways to explore it: one is with an additional yellow bus. Beyond that it can be more than one yellow bus and the other issue is that there will be students who want a discounted MBTA pass. We can continue the program but need to scrutinize the usage by students. What that comes down to is how many students are buying the passes. It is conceivable to me that there is a constituency of students who just want the pass. Intent of the motion is clear - we will need to keep an open dialogue with the committee.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: I want to know what I am supporting.

Jenny Graham: Budget will include assumption that it won't cost students money to get to school. The strategy of how to achieve this will be decided by August 1. The budget needs to reflect a cost capacity that makes it possible for students not to pay to come to school.

Dave Murphy: At the moment, we don't require kids to pay money to come to school. Lack of a yellow bus may be necessitating that. It is not the policy that makes kids have to pay. We want to collect data on this.

Melanie McLaughlin: On this motion, for clarification perspective, the longstanding issue is that we have economically disadvantaged students beyond a two mile radius paying for MBTA passes. Having to choose between the cost of the pass and other choices for their families. I am stunned that this has been the situation. Affects the absentee rates/hunger rates. I would prefer that it would be an MBTA bus but defer the Admin team as to what the costs would be.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: To review on June 1st that no child will need to pay for busing.

ROLL: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatez, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Lungo-Koehn: yes: seven affirmative: motion passes.

David Murphy : I want to ask a question, does the motion contemplate the two mile radius at the secondary level. If the student lives a quarter mile, do we need to provide free transportation?

Jenny Graham: I am not asking to bite off that piece of the apple. I am in concern of students beyond two miles of school.

Dave Murphy; it is sensible but the law says no one beyond 6th grade is entitled to free transportation. We all agree with what the inequity is.

Melanie McLaughlin : Point of information: my issue is around economically disadvantaged students needing to pay for school. Whether within the two mile radius or not, is not the issue to

me. Teachers have paid in the past for their students to have bus passes. MBTA passes do allow for other opportunities for children. Are we focused on the economically disadvantaged in this consideration?

Dave Murphy: It is broader of economically disadvantaged but it is not inclusive of those within two mile radius.

Jenny Graham: I was surprised not to see changes in the finance office. There is no ask to address this?

Dave Murphy: The committee will remember going in FY21 was a two position capacity; one with the chapter 70 allocation, we added the position of Comptroller. We also repurposed an Executive Asst. Position role into the Finance office as a financial role. The back filling of the Exec. Asst. position and the Comptroller were added in FY21. One priority remaining lives in the salary tables that are district wide salary tables. The new exec. Asst position will support all three Asst. Superintendents.

Jenny Graham : I am not in favor of spending capital funds on restrooms, theater, or entrance until we have a master plan for the high school. It is a \$250m - too much money to spend without having a clear plan for the building. Priority of having a plan for the building is important. Greater needs of the building yet unassessed.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I respectfully disagree. Boiler and generator need immediate work.

Melanie McLaughlin: Need MHS vision committee on the agenda. What do you mean tying programmatic opportunities to procurement?

David Murphy: If we are going to increase investment in MBTA passes it would be good to expand experiential learning opportunities to go along with it.

Melanie McLaughlin : I know we have multiple vendors for transportation and we have had issues with one of them. What about a centralized opportunity complaint line so we can know what is happening. We need accountability from the vendors. There has to be some consistency to the complaint process for us to understand as a school committee how to proceed.

David Murphy: This is one of the key reasons we wanted to reorg around the Family Engagement position. The nature of a large organization and we don't actually hear about it. We do currently take vendor complaints very seriously. We do want to know about it right away and have an immediate response at all times.

Melanie McLaughlin : The Director of Pupil Services has always been responsive but I am concerned for those parents who don't know. I have heard two points about the professional development: some specialized staff don't feel that the pd is very targeted for specific licenses/needs. Want to make sure the paras receive appropriate pd choices.

Paul Ruseau: I had to walk 1.1 miles to the bus stop. My experience of making it to the bus or

not going to school, when we do the plan, this ties into Mr. Murphy's staffing levels: are kids within the two mile radius tardy more than outside the two miles? That is a heavy lift but that is a policy decision we are making with no idea of the education outcomes.

Kathy Kreatz: In regards to the motion we approved this evening, are we asking for a report from Mr. Murphy?

Dave Murphy: In order to do this we will have to look at each of the levers. If it is not doable, we will report back to the committee, we will have some solution.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Following up on the comments about the High School. Mayor said there was money available. Vision committee was put on hold after the election because of the concerns of the makeup of the committee and then the pandemic started. It is vital that we decide where to go with this. We need to establish a committee but we want to make sure that the building is liveable for the kids who are there. Key to that - we have to determine what the vision committee is to work on? What is the timeline? We need them to be focused in early September.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I agree - start it up right in the fall.

Paulette Van der Kloot: We need to discuss now what we will do.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: I just want to remind the committee that it was december 2019 when I went before the council and received the \$800 k for the bathrooms. I agree we need to work on a more comprehensive plan. The most modern bathrooms are in the Science wing. I would like that earmarked money from 2019 to be used to update bathroom facilities. Thinking about the needs of the students. I would like to remind the committee of that commitment when the money was released to us.

Jenny Graham: It is not about being opposed to any of those projects. The absence of information makes it more difficult to get what needs to be done in the building. Everyone has an opinion about what needs to be done with MHS. I am opposed to us deciding these expenditures are appropriate without the help of experts.

Kathy Kreatz; I do want to address the issues on the Capital Plan. I have communicated with Mr. McLaughlin about this many times about getting estimates on these projects. Several items are on the agenda for next week's meeting.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: June 1, Tuesday we will have our budget hearing from 7 to 9

Motion to adjourn: Melanie McLaughlin/Kathy Kreatz

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 yes 0 no: meeting adjourned.